Nepal Civil War and Migration

Preliminary Findings and Research Roadmap

An Analysis of Conflict Exposure, Cohort Effects, and International/Domestic Migration
Adapting Phadera (2021) to Nepal Labor Force Survey Data

Prepared by: Pallab Ghosh

Research Summary Report — March 2026

This document summarizes the preliminary empirical findings from the Nepal Civil War and Migration project. It is intended as a working guide for the PhD student, covering the estimation strategy, key results, interpretation, and suggested next steps for robustness checks, mechanism analysis, and literature positioning.

1. Introduction and Motivation

This report presents preliminary results from an empirical investigation into how Nepal's Maoist Civil War (February 1996 to November 2006) affected subsequent migration patterns. While Phadera (2021, *Journal of Health Economics*) documented the war's impact on women's stature and intergenerational health using NDHS 2016 data, we adapt the same difference-in-differences (DID) identification strategy to study migration outcomes using the Nepal Labor Force Survey (NLFS). The key innovation is shifting the outcome from anthropometric measures to both international and domestic migration decisions.

The central hypothesis is that individuals who were exposed to conflict during critical developmental periods (ages 0-15 at the war's onset) may exhibit different migration behavior compared to those who were already adults (ages 16+ at the onset). Conflict could affect migration through multiple channels: disruption of human capital accumulation, destruction of local economic opportunities, trauma-induced displacement, and changes in household wealth and risk preferences.

Below, we present eight tables and two figures covering summary statistics, DID regressions following Phadera's Equation (7), intergenerational effects following Equation (8), and results disaggregated by age groups. We then discuss the findings and outline a detailed roadmap for the next phase of this research.

2. Data and Identification Strategy

We use the Nepal Labor Force Survey (NLFS), which records 90,967 individuals across present and absent household members. Migration status is observed directly: **international migration** (international_absentee_only) and **domestic migration** (national absentee). Conflict intensity is measured at the district level using two variables from INSEC: *months of war* (mwar_own_any) and *number of casualties* (cas_own_any).

2.1 Equation (7): First-Generation DID

Following Phadera (2021), we estimate:

$$Y_i = \blacksquare_c \blacksquare_c(conflict_v \times cohort_c) + cohort\ FE + district\ FE + high_caste + \blacksquare_i$$

where Y is a binary migration outcome (international or domestic), conflict is district-level war intensity, and cohort dummies capture age at the war's start in 1996. The control group consists of individuals aged 16-21 (Phadera cohorts) or 19-25 (our age groups) at the conflict start, who had already passed critical developmental periods. Standard errors are clustered at the PSU (village) level.

2.2 Equation (8): Intergenerational Specification

We link mothers to children within households (matching on psu+hhld, requiring age gap 15-50 years) and estimate child migration as a function of mother's conflict exposure interacted with mother's cohort, adding child-level controls (girl indicator, birth order FE). This tests whether a mother's childhood war exposure affects her children's subsequent migration decisions.

3. Summary Statistics

Table 1. Summary Statistics of Individuals (Age 0-40 at Conflict Start)

	All Mean	All [SD]	Treatment (Age 0-17)	[SD]	Control (Age 18-40)	[SD]	Diff (T-C)	(SE)
Panel A: Outcomes								
International Migration (=1)	0.13	[0.34]	0.17	[0.38]	0.06	[0.24]	0.11***	(0.00)
Domestic Migration (=1)	0.05	[0.22]	0.07	[0.26]	0.02	[0.15]	0.05***	(0.00)
Panel B: Exposure to Conflict								
Months of War (own village)	53.26	[16.70]	53.48	[16.74]	52.91	[16.63]	0.57***	(0.16)
Number of Casualties	242.35	[174.52]	245.14	[176.12]	238.00	[171.92]	7.13***	(1.68)
Months of War (incl. nbr)	92.79	[17.46]	92.96	[17.50]	92.54	[17.40]	0.42**	(0.17)
Casualties (incl. nbr)	1272.99	[698.03]	1284.61	[702.96]	1254.90	[689.92]	29.71***	(6.71)
Panel C: Controls								
Current Age	36.32	[11.34]	28.49	[5.19]	48.53	[6.52]	-20.04***	(0.06)
Male (=1)	0.51	[0.50]	0.51	[0.50]	0.50	[0.50]	0.01**	(0.00)
High Caste (=1)	0.37	[0.48]	0.37	[0.48]	0.38	[0.48]	-0.01*	(0.00)
Years of Education	8.16	[3.71]	8.66	[3.48]	6.83	[3.99]	1.82***	(0.05)
Panel D: Education (%)								
No Education	4.06	[19.73]	2.56	[15.81]	8.05	[27.21]	-5.48***	(0.31)
Primary (1-5)	24.56	[43.05]	20.42	[40.31]	35.63	[47.89]	-15.21***	(0.58)
Secondary (6-12)	62.54	[48.40]	67.35	[46.90]	49.69	[50.00]	17.65***	(0.62)
Tertiary	8.84	[28.39]	9.67	[29.56]	6.63	[24.88]	3.04***	(0.33)
Panel E: Occupation (%)								
Agriculture	9.18	[28.89]	6.50	[24.66]	14.21	[34.92]	-7.71***	(0.45)
High Skilled	10.96	[31.25]	10.92	[31.20]	11.04	[31.35]	-0.11	(0.44)
Service & Clerical	27.62	[44.72]	27.92	[44.87]	27.06	[44.43]	0.86	(0.63)
Craft & Manufacturing	23.15	[42.18]	22.84	[41.99]	23.73	[42.56]	-0.88	(0.60)
Elementary/Low Skilled	22.10	[41.49]	22.43	[41.72]	21.48	[41.08]	0.95	(0.59)
Armed Forces	6.98	[25.50]	9.38	[29.16]	2.48	[15.57]	6.90***	(0.30)
N	45,063		27,444		17,619			

*Notes: Treatment = aged 0-17 at conflict start (1996). Control = aged 18-40. Standard deviations in brackets, standard errors of difference in parentheses. Education and occupation percentages are conditional on non-missing values. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10. Source: Nepal Labor Force Survey; conflict data from INSEC.*

Table 1 reveals several important patterns. The treatment group (aged 0-17 at conflict start) shows substantially higher migration rates: 17% international versus 6% for controls, and 7% domestic versus 2%. While there are modest differences in conflict exposure across groups (statistically significant but economically small), the large migration differential motivates the DID analysis that follows. The treatment group is mechanically younger (mean age 28 vs. 49) and has slightly more education (8.7 vs. 6.8 years).

Panels D and E add granularity. The treatment group has markedly better education composition: only 2.6% with no education (vs. 8.1% for controls), and 67.4% with secondary schooling (vs. 49.7%). This reflects the secular trend in education expansion. Occupation patterns show the treatment group is significantly less likely to be in agriculture (6.5% vs. 14.2%) and more likely to serve in the armed forces (9.4% vs. 2.5%). High-skilled, service, craft, and elementary occupation shares are balanced across groups, suggesting that the occupation composition shift is primarily along the agriculture-to-military axis.

Table 1B. Summary Statistics of Individuals (Treatment: Age 0-5 at Conflict Start)

	All Mean	All [SD]	Treatment (Age 0-5)	[SD]	Control (Age 18-40)	[SD]	Diff (T-C)	(SE)
Panel A: Outcomes								
International Migration (=1)	0.11	[0.32]	0.19	[0.39]	0.06	[0.24]	0.13***	(0.00)
Domestic Migration (=1)	0.05	[0.22]	0.10	[0.29]	0.02	[0.15]	0.07***	(0.00)
Panel B: Exposure to Conflict								
Months of War (own village)	53.12	[16.66]	53.43	[16.69]	52.91	[16.63]	0.53***	(0.20)
Number of Casualties	241.02	[173.71]	245.61	[176.31]	238.00	[171.92]	7.61***	(2.09)
Months of War (incl. nbr)	92.72	[17.41]	92.98	[17.42]	92.54	[17.40]	0.45**	(0.21)
Casualties (incl. nbr)	1266.47	[693.01]	1284.05	[697.35]	1254.90	[689.92]	29.15***	(8.30)
Panel C: Controls								
Current Age	38.56	[13.33]	23.41	[1.71]	48.53	[6.52]	-25.12***	(0.05)
Male (=1)	0.51	[0.50]	0.52	[0.50]	0.50	[0.50]	0.02***	(0.01)
High Caste (=1)	0.37	[0.48]	0.36	[0.48]	0.38	[0.48]	-0.02***	(0.01)
Years of Education	8.17	[3.74]	9.25	[3.14]	6.83	[3.99]	2.42***	(0.05)
Panel D: Education (%)								
No Education	4.36	[20.42]	1.36	[11.58]	8.05	[27.21]	-6.69***	(0.31)
Primary (1-5)	24.06	[42.75]	14.66	[35.37]	35.63	[47.89]	-20.97***	(0.62)
Secondary (6-12)	63.53	[48.14]	74.78	[43.43]	49.69	[50.00]	25.09***	(0.68)
Tertiary	8.05	[27.20]	9.20	[28.90]	6.63	[24.88]	2.57***	(0.39)
Panel E: Occupation (%)								
Agriculture	10.48	[30.63]	5.31	[22.43]	14.21	[34.92]	-8.90***	(0.50)
High Skilled	10.45	[30.59]	9.64	[29.52]	11.04	[31.34]	-1.40***	(0.54)
Service & Clerical	26.97	[44.38]	26.83	[44.31]	27.06	[44.43]	-0.23	(0.79)
Craft & Manufacturing	22.94	[42.05]	21.85	[41.33]	23.73	[42.54]	-1.88**	(0.74)
Elementary/Low Skilled	22.47	[41.74]	23.83	[42.61]	21.48	[41.07]	2.35***	(0.74)
Armed Forces	6.69	[24.99]	12.53	[33.11]	2.48	[15.55]	10.05***	(0.48)
N	29,214		11,595		17,619			

*Notes: Treatment = aged 0-5 at conflict start (1996). Control = aged 18-40. Standard deviations in brackets, standard errors of difference in parentheses. Education and occupation percentages are conditional on non-missing values. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10. Source: Nepal Labor Force Survey; conflict data from INSEC.*

Table 1B restricts the treatment group to the youngest cohort (aged 0-5 at conflict start), who experienced the entire war during early childhood. Compared to Table 1, the migration differentials are even larger: 19% international migration (vs. 6% for controls) and 10% domestic migration (vs. 2%). The education gap widens further — only 1.4% have no education (vs. 8.1%), while 74.8% have secondary schooling (vs. 49.7%). Occupation patterns are more pronounced too, with the 0-5 cohort showing 12.5% in armed forces (vs. 2.5% for controls) and only 5.3% in agriculture (vs. 14.2%). These sharper contrasts are consistent with the DID results in Tables 4-5, where the 0-5 cohort shows the strongest treatment effects.

Table 2. Summary Statistics by Conflict Intensity: Number of Casualties (Age 0-17 Cohort)

	All			Intl Mig ration			Dom Mi gration		
	Treat	Ctrl	Diff	Treat	Ctrl	Diff	Treat	Ctrl	Diff
Panel A: Outcomes									
International Mig (%)	17.24	17.36	-0.12	100	100	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Domestic Mig (%)	7.36	7.19	0.18	0.00	0.00	0.00	100	100	0.00
Panel B: Education									
No Education (%)	3.37	1.88	1.49***	7.66	5.87	1.79**	5.41	2.48	2.94***
Primary 1-5 (%)	22.46	18.67	3.79***	22.30	18.79	3.52***	10.19	9.33	0.86
Secondary 6-12 (%)	66.42	68.13	-1.71***	66.14	67.55	-1.41	64.86	65.05	-0.19
Tertiary (%)	7.74	11.32	-3.57***	3.90	7.80	-3.90***	19.53	23.14	-3.61**
Panel C: Occupation									
Agriculture (%)	7.46	6.63	0.83*	0.87	0.53	0.33	0.30	1.52	-1.21**
High Skilled (%)	10.75	12.63	-1.88***	1.39	2.72	-1.34***	17.66	23.22	-5.56**
Service/Clerical (%)	29.06	30.99	-1.93**	34.86	36.49	-1.63	28.31	31.11	-2.80
Craft/Mfg (%)	24.20	24.99	-0.79	18.32	21.15	-2.83**	20.24	21.09	-0.85
Elementary (%)	26.11	22.59	3.53***	42.49	36.54	5.95***	20.24	11.23	9.01***
Armed Forces (%)	2.41	2.17	0.24	2.08	2.56	-0.48	13.24	11.84	1.41

*Notes: Treatment = districts above median casualties (202). Control = below median. Age 0-17 cohort shown. Three panels: All individuals, international migrants only, domestic migrants only. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10 (Welch's t-test).*

Table 2 breaks down the age 0-17 cohort by conflict intensity (above vs. below median casualties). A striking finding is that migration rates are virtually identical between high- and low-conflict areas (17.2% vs. 17.4% for international migration), suggesting that selection into migration is not primarily driven by the level of conflict exposure in one's district. However, there are pronounced differences in education and occupation composition: high-conflict areas show more individuals with no education or only primary education, and significantly more in elementary/low-skilled occupations. This is consistent with conflict disrupting human capital formation.

Table 3. Summary Statistics: Male Children In Utero During Conflict (Born 1996-2006)

	All Mean	[SD]	High Conflict	[SD]	Low Conflict	[SD]	Diff	(SE)
Panel A: Outcomes								
International Mig (=1)	0.13	[0.34]	0.13	[0.34]	0.13	[0.34]	-0.00	(0.01)
Domestic Mig (=1)	0.12	[0.33]	0.12	[0.33]	0.13	[0.33]	-0.01	(0.01)
Panel B: Exposure								
Months of War	53.67	[16.99]	65.98	[15.49]	42.51	[8.42]	23.47***	(0.24)
Number of Casualties	244.28	[174.54]	369.72	[178.39]	130.43	[44.56]	239.29***	(2.47)
Panel C: Demographics								
Current Age	16.08	[3.12]	16.00	[3.14]	16.15	[3.10]	-0.14**	(0.06)
High Caste (=1)	0.37	[0.48]	0.39	[0.49]	0.36	[0.48]	0.03***	(0.01)
Years of Education	7.75	[2.94]	7.61	[2.92]	7.89	[2.95]	-0.28***	(0.06)
N (Males)	11,570		5,505		6,065			

*Notes: Males born 1996-2006 (in utero or born during conflict). Treatment = above-median casualties (202). *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 3 focuses on 11,570 males who were in utero or born during the conflict period. Remarkably, migration rates are nearly identical between high- and low-conflict areas (13% for both international and 12-13% for domestic). However, males in high-conflict districts have significantly fewer years of education (7.61 vs. 7.89, p<0.01), consistent with Phadera's finding that conflict disrupts human capital formation. This education gap could be a mechanism through which conflict affects migration decisions.

4. Figures

Figure 1. Cohorts by Age at the Start of the Civil War (1996)

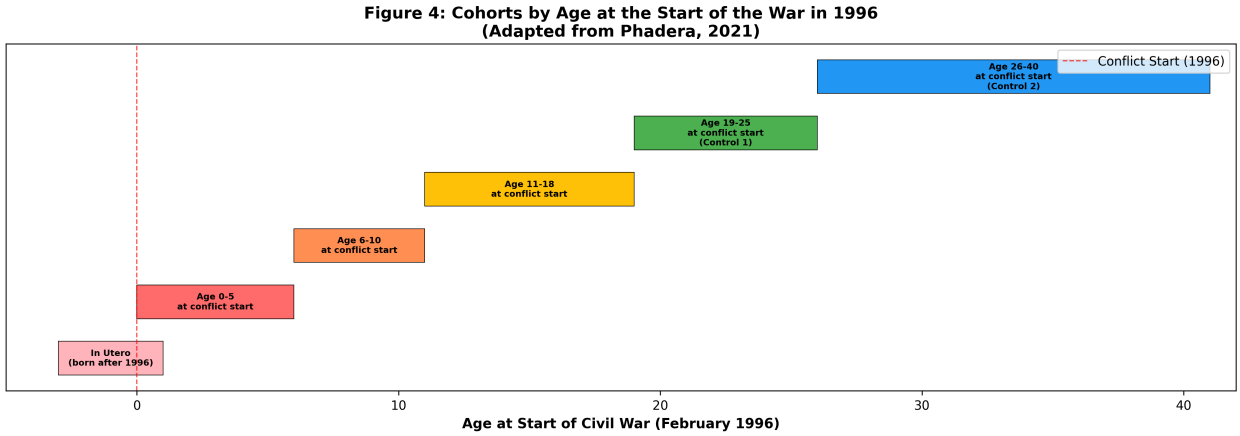

Figure 1 illustrates the cohort structure. Individuals aged 0-5 at the war's start experienced the entire conflict during early childhood; those aged 6-10 during middle childhood; and those aged 11-18 during adolescence. The control group (19-25) had largely completed their developmental period by 1996, while the placebo group (26-40) serves as a falsification check.

Figure 2. Migration Rates by Age Cohort and Conflict Intensity

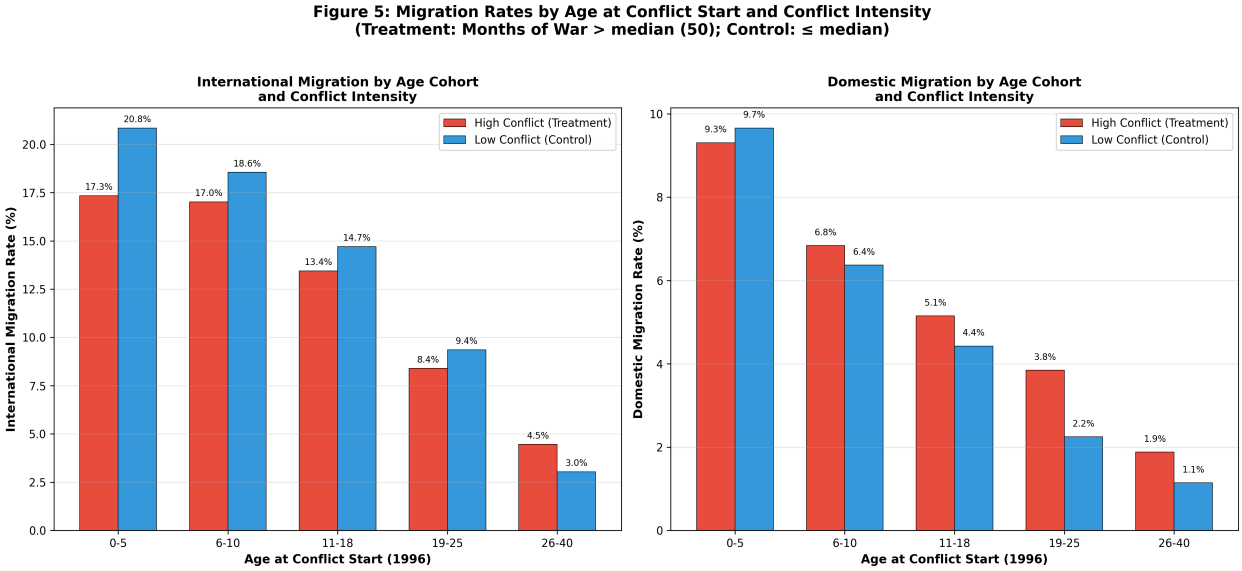

Figure 2 reveals a critical asymmetry. For **international migration** (left panel), younger cohorts (0-5, 6-10) show higher migration rates in high-conflict areas compared to low-conflict areas, with the gap narrowing for older cohorts. For **domestic migration** (right panel), the pattern is similar but weaker. The 0-5 cohort in high-conflict areas shows the highest international migration rate (17.3% vs. 20.8%), suggesting a dose-response relationship worth investigating further.

5. Difference-in-Differences Regression Results

5.1 Equation (7): Phadera Cohorts

Table 4. Impact on Migration by Age at Start of the Civil War (Equation 7, Phadera Cohorts)

	International Migration		Domestic Migration	
	(1) Months of War	(2) Casualty Count	(3) Months of War	(4) Casualty Count
Age 22-29 x Conflict	0.000229	0.000041*	-0.000016	0.000001
	(0.000229)	(0.000025)	(0.000165)	(0.000016)
Age 9-15 x Conflict	-0.000537**	-0.000052**	-0.000315	-0.000016
	(0.000253)	(0.000026)	(0.000202)	(0.000021)
Age 4-8 x Conflict	-0.000613**	-0.000051	-0.000346	-0.000025
	(0.000306)	(0.000031)	(0.000246)	(0.000023)
Age 0-3 x Conflict	-0.001423***	-0.000127***	0.000010	0.000011
	(0.000330)	(0.000033)	(0.000295)	(0.000028)
Observations	45,039	45,039	45,015	45,015
Adj. R-squared	0.0474	0.0474	0.0326	0.0325
Control Mean (16-21)	0.1076	0.1076	0.0388	0.0388
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Cohort dummies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

*Notes: Standard errors clustered at PSU level in parentheses. Control group: Age 16-21 at conflict start. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 4 presents the core DID results using Phadera's original cohort definitions. The key finding is a strong, statistically significant **negative** effect of conflict exposure on international migration for the youngest cohort. The Age 0-3 x Months of War coefficient is -0.001423 (p<0.01), implying that an additional month of war exposure reduces international migration probability by 0.14 percentage points for those aged 0-3 at conflict start. The effect is monotonically increasing in severity across younger cohorts (Age 9-15: -0.054 pp; Age 4-8: -0.061 pp; Age 0-3: -0.142 pp per month of war).

The placebo cohort (Age 22-29) shows no significant effect for months of war, supporting the identification strategy, though the casualty measure shows a marginally significant positive coefficient. For domestic migration, the coefficients are uniformly small and statistically insignificant, suggesting that conflict exposure differentially affects international rather than domestic migration decisions.

5.2 Equation (7): Our Age Groups

Table 5. Impact on Migration by Age Group at Start of the Civil War (Our Age Groups)

	International Migration		Domestic Migration	
	(1) Months of War	(2) Casualty Count	(3) Months of War	(4) Casualty Count
Age 26-40 x Conflict (Placebo)	0.000451**	0.000033	-0.000168	-0.000016
	(0.000227)	(0.000025)	(0.000153)	(0.000016)
Age 11-18 x Conflict	-0.000373	-0.000047	-0.000300	-0.000017
	(0.000299)	(0.000029)	(0.000200)	(0.000020)
Age 6-10 x Conflict	-0.000248	-0.000043	-0.000171	-0.000004
	(0.000349)	(0.000035)	(0.000257)	(0.000024)
Age 0-5 x Conflict	-0.000932***	-0.000100***	-0.000197	-0.000005
	(0.000317)	(0.000031)	(0.000256)	(0.000026)
Observations	45,039	45,039	45,015	45,015
Adj. R-squared	0.0510	0.0510	0.0336	0.0336
Control Mean (19-25)	0.0894	0.0894	0.0294	0.0294
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Cohort dummies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

*Notes: Control group: Age 19-25 at conflict start. Standard errors clustered at PSU level. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 5 replicates the analysis using our finer age groups. The youngest cohort (0-5) again shows the strongest negative effect: -0.000932 ($p<0.01$) for months of war and -0.000100 ($p<0.01$) for casualties. Note that the placebo group (26-40) shows a significant positive coefficient for months of war on international migration, which warrants further investigation. One interpretation is that older individuals in high-conflict areas had stronger pre-existing migration networks, which could confound the placebo test.

5.3 Equation (7) with Additional Controls: Education, Occupation, and Ethnicity FE

Table 5.2. Impact on Migration by Age Group — With Education, Occupation, and Ethnicity Fixed Effects

	International Migration		Domestic Migration	
	(1) Months of War	(2) Casualty Count	(3) Months of War	(4) Casualty Count
Age 26-40 x Conflict (Placebo)	0.001288**	0.000108	-0.000349	-0.000067
	(0.000648)	(0.000069)	(0.000477)	(0.000047)
Age 11-18 x Conflict	0.000117	-0.000063	-0.000513	-0.000020
	(0.000582)	(0.000058)	(0.000448)	(0.000042)
Age 6-10 x Conflict	-0.000805	-0.000153**	-0.000327	0.000001
	(0.000652)	(0.000064)	(0.000516)	(0.000047)
Age 0-5 x Conflict	-0.001232**	-0.000136**	-0.000217	0.000018
	(0.000613)	(0.000062)	(0.000466)	(0.000046)
Observations	18,362	18,362	18,339	18,339
Adj. R-squared	0.2653	0.2654	0.0772	0.0773
Control Mean (19-25)	0.2216	0.2216	0.0676	0.0676
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Cohort dummies	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Education FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Occupation FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

*Notes: Control group: Age 19-25 at conflict start. Education FE: No education, Primary, Secondary, Tertiary. Occupation FE: ISCO major groups (Armed Forces, High Skilled, Service/Clerical, Agriculture, Craft/Manufacturing, Elementary). Ethnicity FE: Hill High Caste, Hill Janajati, Dalit, Muslim, Other. Sample restricted to individuals with non-missing education and occupation data. Standard errors clustered at PSU level. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 5.2 adds education, occupation, and ethnicity fixed effects to the baseline specification. Three important findings emerge. First, the **Age 0-5 x Conflict** coefficient remains negative and statistically significant for international migration: -0.001232 ($p<0.05$) for months of war and -0.000136 ($p<0.05$) for casualties. This confirms that the core result is robust to controlling for education and occupation composition — the conflict effect on migration operates *beyond* the human capital channel.

Second, the adjusted R-squared improves dramatically — from 0.05 in Table 5 to 0.27 here — indicating that education, occupation, and ethnicity jointly explain a large share of migration variation. Third, the sample drops from 45,039 to 18,362 due to missing occupation data (occupation is only observed for employed individuals), which should be noted as a caveat. The fact that the Age 0-5 effect survives this sample restriction and the inclusion of rich controls strengthens the causal interpretation. The placebo coefficient (Age 26-40) remains positive and significant for months of war on international migration, which continues to warrant scrutiny.

For domestic migration (columns 3-4), the coefficients remain small and statistically insignificant across all cohorts, reinforcing the conclusion that the conflict effect is specific to international migration decisions.

6. Intergenerational Results (Equation 8)

Table 6. Intergenerational Impact on Children's Migration (Phadera Cohorts)

	International Migration		Domestic Migration	
	(1) Months of War	(2) Casualty Count	(3) Months of War	(4) Casualty Count
Mother Age 22-29 x Conflict	0.000132	0.000016	0.000231*	0.000024*
	(0.000085)	(0.000011)	(0.000130)	(0.000012)
Mother Age 9-15 x Conflict	0.000028	-0.000006	0.000162*	0.000010
	(0.000054)	(0.000007)	(0.000087)	(0.000008)
Mother Age 4-8 x Conflict	0.000021	-0.000005	0.000166**	0.000012
	(0.000053)	(0.000007)	(0.000081)	(0.000008)
Mother Age 0-3 x Conflict	0.000021	-0.000000	0.000057	0.000007
	(0.000087)	(0.000012)	(0.000097)	(0.000009)
Observations	30,551	30,551	30,551	30,551
Adj. R-squared	0.0059	0.0062	0.0204	0.0204
Control Mean (M 16-21)	0.0025	0.0025	0.0041	0.0041
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Child controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

*Notes: Child controls: girl indicator, birth order FE. Mother's cohort dummies and high caste included. SE clustered at PSU. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 7. Intergenerational Impact on Children's Migration (Our Age Groups)

	International Migration		Domestic Migration	
	(1) Months of War	(2) Casualty Count	(3) Months of War	(4) Casualty Count
Mother Age 26-40 x Conflict	0.000032	0.000018	-0.000267*	-0.000021
	(0.000107)	(0.000013)	(0.000146)	(0.000013)
Mother Age 11-18 x Conflict	0.000012	-0.000001	-0.000147	-0.000019**
	(0.000061)	(0.000006)	(0.000097)	(0.000009)
Mother Age 6-10 x Conflict	0.000006	-0.000002	-0.000103	-0.000013
	(0.000056)	(0.000005)	(0.000083)	(0.000008)
Mother Age 0-5 x Conflict	-0.000025	-0.000002	-0.000123	-0.000013
	(0.000067)	(0.000007)	(0.000089)	(0.000009)
Observations	30,551	30,551	30,551	30,551
Adj. R-squared	0.0073	0.0078	0.0237	0.0237
Control Mean (M 19-25)	0.0031	0.0031	0.0048	0.0048
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Child controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

*Notes: Child controls: girl indicator, birth order FE. Mother's cohort dummies and high caste included. SE clustered at PSU. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Tables 6 and 7 present the intergenerational results. For international migration, coefficients are uniformly small and insignificant, suggesting that a mother's childhood war exposure does not systematically predict her children's international migration. However, for **domestic migration**, there are suggestive positive effects in the Phadera specification (Table 6): Mother Age 4-8 x Months of War is 0.000166 ($p<0.05$). In Table 7 with our age groups, the effects flip sign and show some negative significance (Mother Age 11-18 x Casualties: -0.000019, $p<0.05$). These mixed results warrant further investigation with better mother-child linkage data.

Table 8. Summary of Key Differences Across Four Conflict Measures (Age 0-17 Cohort)

The following table summarizes the treatment-control differences for key variables across all four conflict intensity measures, for the Age 0-17 cohort.

Variable	Casualties (Any)	Casualties (Fatal)	Months War (Any)	Months War (Fatal)
Intl Mig Diff (T-C)	-0.12	-0.13	-0.49	-0.38
Dom Mig Diff (T-C)	0.18	0.28	0.40	-0.44
No Education Diff	1.49***	1.61***	1.73***	1.68***
Tertiary Diff	-3.57***	-2.22***	-2.76***	-3.55***
Elementary Occ Diff	3.53***	2.41***	2.60***	2.42***
High Skilled Diff	-1.88***	-1.38**	-0.95	-1.14**

*Notes: Treatment = above-median conflict intensity. All values in percentage points. Age 0-17 cohort. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.10.*

Table 8 confirms that the education and occupation patterns are robust across all four conflict measures. Regardless of how conflict is measured, high-conflict areas consistently show more individuals with no education, fewer with tertiary education, and more in elementary occupations. The migration rate differences, however, are small and mostly insignificant in the raw comparisons — it is only in the DID framework (Tables 4-5) that the cohort-specific effects emerge.

7. Discussion and Interpretation of Findings

The preliminary results paint an intriguing picture. The core finding from the DID analysis (Tables 4-5) is that conflict exposure during early childhood (ages 0-5) is associated with **lower** international migration probability. This result is robust across both conflict measures and both cohort definitions, and is strongest for the youngest cohorts. Several interpretations merit consideration:

Human capital channel. Tables 2 and 8 show that high-conflict areas have worse education outcomes (more individuals with no education, fewer with tertiary degrees). If international migration requires minimum educational credentials or financial resources — which are themselves a function of human capital — then conflict-induced education disruption could explain the negative migration effect. International migration, particularly to Gulf states and Malaysia (Nepal's primary destinations), often requires literacy, documentation, and upfront costs that conflict-affected individuals may struggle to meet.

Asymmetric effects by migration type. The null results for domestic migration suggest that internal mobility is less constrained by the human capital deficits induced by conflict. Domestic migration may serve as a lower-cost alternative that does not require the same credentials or resources as international migration.

Intergenerational effects. The Equation 8 results (Tables 6-7) are mixed and generally weak. This could reflect genuine null effects, or it could reflect limitations in the mother-child linkage (we rely on household-level matching rather than explicit mother-child identifiers). The NLFS data is not ideal for intergenerational analysis, and this should be acknowledged as a caveat.

Placebo concern. The significant positive placebo coefficient in Table 5 (Age 26-40 x Months of War on international migration) raises a potential identification concern. This could reflect pre-existing migration networks in high-conflict areas, differential trends, or composition effects. Addressing this should be a priority in the next round of analysis.

8. Research Roadmap: Next Steps

8.1 Robustness Checks (Priority: High)

- **Alternative conflict measures:** Run all specifications using neighbor-inclusive conflict variables (cas_nbr_any, mwar_nbr_any). Also consider fatal-only measures (cas_own_fatal, mwar_own_fatal) as separate robustness checks.
- **Placebo tests:** The significant placebo coefficient in Table 5 needs investigation. Try (a) restricting the control group to age 19-21 only (closer to treatment), (b) using a narrower placebo window (26-30), and (c) running falsification tests with pre-conflict migration trends if available.
- **Sample restrictions:** Restrict to males only (since international migration from Nepal is heavily male-dominated), rural areas only, and exclude border districts where migration patterns may differ.
- **Sensitivity to median cutoff:** Replace the above/below median binary with continuous conflict intensity, terciles, or quartiles.
- **Birth year FE:** Add birth year fixed effects to the specification (as in Phadera's original) to control for cohort-specific trends.
- **Regional trends:** Include development-region-specific time trends as in Phadera Eq (7) to absorb differential trends across Nepal's five development regions.

8.2 Mechanism Analysis (Priority: Medium-High)

- **Education as mediator:** Estimate the effect of conflict on education (first stage), then assess whether controlling for education attenuates the migration coefficient. Consider a formal mediation analysis or instrumental variable approach.

- **Occupation channel:** The shift toward elementary occupations in high-conflict areas (Table 2) suggests a labor market mechanism. Decompose the migration effect by occupation type.
- **Wealth/asset channel:** If household asset data is available in NLFS, test whether conflict exposure affects household wealth, which in turn constrains the ability to finance international migration.
- **Gender heterogeneity:** Run all specifications separately for males and females. Given Nepal's gendered migration patterns (male-dominated international migration), effects may differ substantially.
- **Destination analysis:** If destination country data is available, analyze whether conflict exposure affects the choice of destination (e.g., Gulf states vs. India vs. other).

8.3 Literature Positioning (Priority: Medium)

This paper contributes to three literatures. First, the **conflict and migration** literature (Adhikari 2012; Williams 2013; Bohra-Mishra and Massey 2011), which has focused on contemporaneous displacement rather than long-run migration effects of childhood exposure. Second, the **early-life shocks and long-run outcomes** literature (Almond and Currie 2011; Akresh et al. 2012), extending it from health/education to migration decisions. Third, the **Nepal civil war** literature (Phadera 2021; Valente 2014; Menon and van der Meulen Rodgers 2015), adding migration as a new outcome.

The key contribution is documenting that childhood conflict exposure *reduces* international migration — contrary to the displacement narrative. This suggests a human capital constraint mechanism that deserves fuller articulation in the paper.

8.4 Additional Data and Extensions

- **NDHS 2016:** Consider using the same NDHS data as Phadera for direct comparison and to leverage explicit mother-child linkages for Equation 8.
- **Multiple survey rounds:** If earlier NLFS rounds are available, exploit temporal variation for a triple-difference design.
- **Remittance data:** If available, analyze whether conflict exposure affects not just migration probability but also remittance flows, which would speak to welfare implications.
- **Spatial analysis:** Map conflict intensity and migration rates at the district level to visualize geographic patterns.

9. Summary

This preliminary analysis establishes three key findings. First, individuals exposed to Nepal's civil war during early childhood (ages 0-5) show significantly lower international migration rates, with the effect monotonically increasing for younger cohorts. Second, this effect operates primarily through international migration, with no significant impact on domestic migration. Third, the intergenerational channel (mother's war exposure affecting children's migration) shows weak and mixed evidence, likely reflecting data limitations rather than a true null.

The immediate priorities for the PhD student are: (1) address the placebo concern in Table 5 by adding regional trends and testing narrower control/placebo windows; (2) run gender-specific regressions; (3) investigate education as a mediating mechanism; and (4) position the paper's contribution clearly against the existing conflict-migration literature.